

Week 1: Why Study the Civil War?/The Political Economy of Slavery

Questions

1. Many historians pinpoint slavery as the major cause of the Civil War. Do you agree or disagree and why? If there had been no slavery, would the Civil War have occurred over the issue of states' rights?

2. From your assigned reading and from what you have learned in lectures, select at least three major differences between the North and the South and explain why these differences might have led to secession.

Key Terms

- Missouri Compromise
- Fugitive Slave Act
- Harriet Jacobs
- Democratic Party
- George Fitzhugh

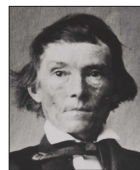
The Flags of the Civil War



The Union's National Flag was the Stars and Stripes (left). The one shown flew over Fort Sumter during the Rebel bombardment of that fort in April, 1861. At the start of the war, "Old Glory" had 33 stars, typically placed in rows, in the blue canton. By the war's end, it had 35 stars, Kansas and West Virginia having been admitted to the Union in 1861 and 1863, respectively.

The Confederates' first national flag (center) could not always be distinguished from the Stars and Stripes in battle—a critical problem in a war where flags were used to keep regiments organized while they fought. Consequently, the battle flag (right) was used instead.

How Important Was Slavery to Secessionists?



The new constitution has put at rest, forever, all the agitating questions relating to our peculiar institution African slavery as it exists amongst us the proper status of the negro in our form of civilization. This was the immediate cause of the late rupture and present revolution. [Thomas] Jefferson in his forecast, had anticipated this, as the "rock upon which the old Union would split." He was right. What was conjecture with him, is now a realized fact. But whether he fully comprehended the great truth upon which that rock stood and stands, may be doubted. The prevailing ideas entertained by him and most of the leading statesmen at the time of the formation of the old constitution, were that the enslavement of the African was in violation of the laws of nature; that it was wrong in principle, socially, morally, and politically. It was an evil they knew not well how to deal with, but the general opinion of the men of that day was that, somehow or other in the order of Providence, the institution would be evanescent and pass away. This idea, though not incorporated in the constitution, was the prevailing idea at that time. The constitution, it is true, secured every essential guarantee to the institution while it should last, and hence no argument can be justly urged against the constitutional guarantees thus secured, because of the common sentiment of the day. Those ideas, however, were fundamentally wrong. They rested upon the assumption of the equality of races. This was an error. It was a sandy foundation, and the government built upon it fell when the "storm came and the wind blew." ... Our new government is founded upon exactly the opposite idea; its foundations are laid, its cornerstone rests, upon the great truth that the negro is not equal to the white man; that slavery subordination to the superior race is his natural and normal condition. This, our new government, is the first, in the history of the world, based upon this great physical, philosophical, and moral truth.

- Confederate Vice-President Alexander H. Stephens, March 21, 1861



[Secession became necessary due to the rise of a political party], "organized for the purpose of obtaining the administration of the Government, with the avowed object of using its power for the total exclusion of the slave States from all participation in the benefits of the public domain acquired by all the States in common, whether by conquest or purchase; of surrounding them entirely by States in which slavery should be prohibited; of thus rendering the property in slaves so insecure as to be comparatively worthless, and thereby annihilating in effect property worth thousands of millions of dollars. This party, thus organized, succeeded in the month of November last in the election of its candidate for the Presidency of the United States."

- Confederate President Jefferson Davis, April 29, 1861

OUTRAGE.

Fellow Citizens,
AN
ABOLITIONIST,
of the most revolting character is among you, exciting the feelings of the North against the South. A seditious Lecture is to be delivered.
THIS EVENING,
at 7 o'clock, at the Presbyterian Church in Cannon-street.
You are requested to attend and unite in putting down and silencing by penceable means this tool of evil and fanaticism. Let the rights of the States guaranteed by the Constitution be protected.
Feb. 27, 1837. *The Union forever!*

VALUABLE GANG OF YOUNG NEGROES

By JOS. A. BEARD.

Will be sold at Auction,
ON WEDNESDAY, 25TH INST.

At 12 o'clock, at Banks' Arcade,
17 Valuable Young Negroes, Men and Women, Field Hands.
Sold for no fault; with the best city guarantees.

Sale Positive and without reserve!
TERMS CASH.

New Orleans, March 24, 1840.

Above: 1837 Poster calling on Charlestonians to protest an abolitionist meeting planned for a local church. Such meetings would not be possible by the 1850s.

Below: Announcement of an 1840 slave auction in New Orleans, Louisiana. Such auctions were commonplace in the city—when Abraham Lincoln witnessed one as a young man in 1828, it affirmed his already strong disdain for the institution.